“Difficulty is not automatically depth. Opacity is not automatically intelligence.” Sohel Georgiadis
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On Frictionalism

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Abstract. This essay develops an account of freedom through encounters with resistance. A wheel spinning on ice introduces the problem of effort without traction. The argument then moves through learning, relationships, tools, evidence, and writing to ask how capacities form when the world can answer an intention with something unexpected. It distinguishes resistance that supports agency from conditions that exhaust or destroy the capacity to respond. Consent, power, resources, and the possibility of leaving are central to that distinction. The proposal remains provisional and rejects any simple identification of suffering with growth.



Hendrick Avercamp, Winter Landscape with Ice Skaters. Rijksmuseum, SK-A-1718. Public-domain reproduction via Wikimedia Commons.

1. The wheel and the question of freedom

The ice had come overnight, and by morning the road before the gate had turned into a single grey sheet, smooth enough to catch the light though. I did not notice it until the car was already on it. I pressed the accelerator the way anyone does when a wheel stops responding: harder. The engine answered at once, its pitch rising, doing exactly what an engine is built to do. The rear wheel began to spin, faster than it would have spun on gravel, faster than it needed to, spinning with something that looked, for a moment, like power. And the car did not move.

I sat there longer than the situation required, listening to the engine work harder for less result, watching the wheel blur into a single black ring. It had never been freer. Nothing was holding it back, no mud, no gravel, no crack in the tar to catch the tread. And it had never been more useless. All that force, and the car sat exactly where it had been sitting a minute before, as though it had decided, on some level, to stay.

What struck me once the small comedy of it passed (I did eventually get out, laid something rough under the tyre, felt the old bite return) was how completely the wheel's problem looked like the opposite of a problem. Shown only the spinning wheel, without the stillness of the car around it, I might have called it free. It was not straining against a slope, or catching on a root, or fighting the small viciousness of gravel. It turned as easily as a thought turns over in an idle mind. And that ease was exactly what had disconnected it from the ground.

I want to be careful here, because a wheel is not a person, and a road is not a life. I do not think a philosophy can be built by simply enlarging a fact about physics until it covers grief and love and the fear of dying. A body is not a tyre. Whatever this book is going to argue, it cannot be argued by analogy alone, and the ice on that road proves nothing about a mind. But it did give me a question, the way an ordinary object sometimes hands you a question you did not think to ask it. The wheel had lost its resistance and, in losing it, had lost the very thing resistance was for.

2. Resistance and the wish for ease

Most of us, if asked directly, would say that freedom means encountering less resistance, and it is a reasonable thing to believe, because so much of what actually constrains a life is resistance in an ugly, undeniable form. A locked door is resistance, and no one needs convincing that removing the lock is a kind of liberation. An unjust law is resistance, built to make certain speech dangerous or certain movement illegal, and removing it does not damage a person's growth; it returns something that was taken. Poverty is resistance, blunt and relentless, closing off school, medicine, the ordinary experiment of trying something and seeing what happens. Illness is resistance the body mounts against its own intentions, and no philosophy of mine is going to tell a person recovering from one that the sickness was secretly a gift. A relationship built on control is resistance disguised as concern, and the person inside it does not need a book to explain that

leaving would be a kind of breathing.

In every one of these cases, removing the resistance is not a philosophical problem. It is simply right, and I want to say this as plainly as I can before anything else, because a philosophy that begins by praising resistance and only remembers to mention this later has already told a lie by omission. Whatever this book eventually argues about the value of friction, it does not argue that the locked door should stay locked, that poverty builds character, or that a person inside a controlling relationship should stay there in the name of growth. Those are not case studies in the discipline of friction. They are the reasons an honest philosophy of friction has to keep proving, chapter after chapter, that it is not simply cruelty with a university degree.

But there is a step that tends to follow these examples, quietly enough that we rarely examine it, and it is the step this opening wants to slow down and look at directly. Because removing certain kinds of resistance clearly makes us freer, it becomes easy to conclude, almost without noticing the conclusion arrive, that removing resistance in general is what freedom is made of, and that the more completely we remove it, the freer we become. Each example above is a form of resistance, and each is worth removing, so the reasoning continues: resistance is the enemy, in every form, at every scale, and a life with none of it left would be the freest life available to a human being.

That is the assumption worth slowing down and examining. Not to defend the lock or the controlling hand, but to ask what else travels along with resistance when we decide to remove it wholesale, the way a wheel discovers, too late, that the very thing making the road difficult was also the thing making the road available to it at all.

Consider what a completely smooth life would actually contain, if such a life were possible. It would have no waiting long enough to test whether a desire was real or only a passing appetite mistaken for one. It would have no disagreement capable of altering a belief, because every opinion would arrive home a little more confirmed than it left. It would contain no uncertainty sharp enough to produce fear, because the future would already have been mapped in advance. No relationship would be able to end without the leaving person's full permission. No future would arrive carrying an event the person living toward it had not already approved.

It is worth admitting, honestly, how much this appeals. I am not going to pretend the wish for such a life belongs to someone weaker or shallower than I am. It comes, more often than not, from having already been hurt by resistance in its cruel form: by a childhood where every disagreement in the house ended in punishment, by a love that changed its mind without warning, by an illness or a rejection or a public failure that still burns years later when it returns at three in the morning. A person who has lived through enough of that does not dream of a frictionless life because they are shallow. They dream of it because they have already paid, in a currency nobody chooses, for what resistance can cost. That wish does not deserve mockery, and I am suspicious of any philosophy, including my own on its worse days, that mistakes a wounded person's longing for safety for a failure of nerve.

3. Assistance, judgement and the world

Somewhere between resistance that harms and resistance that forms, there is a quieter zone, where assistance turns into substitution without anyone deciding it should. I notice it most clearly in small tools, because they are honest about what they are doing even when we are not honest with ourselves about using them. I have lived in cities for months without learning their shape, because a voice in my pocket told me, at every turn, which way to go. I arrived, every time, but could never have drawn the route from memory afterward, because I had never needed to hold it in my head. The tool did not fail me. It succeeded completely, and in succeeding completely it quietly took over a kind of knowing that used to belong to the traveller. This is not a reason to distrust assistance. A person lost in an unfamiliar city at night is not better served by the old kind of struggle. The narrower question is what happens when a system removes not just labour but the possibility of getting a thing wrong, and with it the occasion on which judgement used to form. Add that up across enough small tasks quietly handed to something that will not let us fail at them, and a person can reach forty extremely competent at living inside systems that do their living for them, and strangely undeveloped at navigating what those systems do not cover.

The same question follows a student into a classroom. A proof that resists solution for an hour is, for that hour, doing something to a mind that the same proof, solved and explained in the first five minutes, cannot do. I am not romanticising confusion. A student stuck for a week and then humiliated for not seeing what the teacher considers obvious is not being sharpened; that is a different chapter, and a darker one. But a teacher who answers too quickly, out of a wish to see the discomfort end, can take from a student the specific hour in which not-knowing was about to turn into knowing on its own. Assistance given at the wrong moment stops being assistance. It becomes a substitute for the capacity it was meant to serve.

People do this to each other as well. A friend who has learned to agree with everything I say is easier to be around than one who occasionally tells me I am wrong, and for a while that ease can look like a small, private peace. But peace between two people is not the same thing as the absence of disagreement. A silence can mean that harmony has been reached, or it can mean that one person has quietly decided it is no longer worth it to object, and I cannot always tell the difference from the outside, enjoying how smoothly the conversation is going. A smoothness we enjoy is not always evidence that nothing is wrong.

There is an older, plainer way to say some of this. Part of what we mean by the real, as opposed to the imagined or the wished-for, is precisely that it does not simply rearrange itself around our intentions. A stone has a weight that does not change because I would prefer it lighter. A language, however long I have loved it, will not hand my private experience across to another person without losing something on the way, some heat, some shade of the original feeling that cannot be posted intact into anyone else's skull. A friend, if the friendship is real and not merely comfortable, will

occasionally think I am mistaken, and will say so. A person I love remains, however much I love them, a separate mind capable of changing in directions I did not choose. A future, arriving, will contain at least one event that the person living toward it did not write into the plan.

It is worth pausing before this turns into a general endorsement of resistance, because plenty of things resist us without being real in any way worth honouring. A delusion can be extremely resistant to correction. A cruel bureaucracy resists a person's simplest requests for weeks, and there is nothing to admire in that resistance, nothing forming the person on the other end of it except exhaustion. Resistance, on its own, proves nothing about value. So the claim worth making is narrower than resistance is good: something about the real, specifically, seems to depend on its refusal to become a perfect copy of what we already wanted. A bow drawn across a string that offers no resistance at all does not produce a note. It produces motion, and silence, at the same time. The music was never in the bow alone. It required the string to push back in exactly the way strings are built to push back, and the resistance was not a flaw in the design of the instrument. It was the design.

A world that agreed with me about everything, that rearranged its facts the moment my preferences changed, might feel, for a while, like the most peaceful place a person could live in. I am less sure it would go on feeling like a world. At some point it would start to resemble an instrument that could only ever return the note I had just hummed into it, an echo with better manners, and I do not know that an echo, however faithful, can be loved, argued with, disappointed by, or trusted, in the way an actual other thing can be.

So here is a question worth sitting with, unanswered, for now: is it possible that certain capacities we value most in a human life do not simply survive resistance, the way a plant survives a drought, but require it, the way that plant requires actual water and not the idea of water? Judgement seems to develop specifically in the absence of an automatic answer; where the answer is given immediately, judgement has nothing left to do. Patience needs a gap between wanting and having, because without the gap there is nothing to call patience, only immediate satisfaction wearing a nicer name. Skill comes from a material, wood, language, an instrument, that resists the hand until the hand learns what the material required of it. To call someone brave assumes the outcome was actually uncertain. Love depends, oddly, on the very separateness that also makes it possible to lose someone; if the other person could not, even in principle, change or leave, I am not sure what would be left to call love rather than possession. Responsibility, too, depends on consequences that are not guaranteed to be undone; remove the chance of a real consequence and what is left is performance.

I want to be extremely careful with this question, because it sits directly next to one of the ugliest ideas available to a comfortable person: the idea that suffering builds character, that deprivation makes people stronger, that trauma is secretly a kind of education, that oppressive conditions are, if you squint, instructive. I do not believe any of that, and a version of Frictionalism that slides toward believing it will have failed

at the one job this book actually has. The question above is not about whether pain is good for people. It is about a narrower, more defensible question: what conditions make certain human capacities possible to form at all. The answer may involve a small, survivable, chosen or at least bearable friction, the kind involved in a difficult proof or an uncertain courtship, without extending one inch toward justifying poverty, cruelty, or war. A person does not need to be hungry to develop patience. They need, at minimum, the ordinary experience of wanting something they cannot have this second. Those are not the same demand, and they will stay separate for the rest of this book, however tempting it becomes, later, to blur them for a stronger-sounding sentence.

4. The limits of the argument

I have to stop here and put the knife against my own argument, because a philosophy that only turns its blade outward cannot be trusted. Here is the objection, stated as strongly as it can be managed: perhaps everything written above is simply the moral imagination of someone who has not yet met resistance in its worst form. It is easy, from a warm room, with an education, with the money for a hospital and the legal right to leave a bad marriage, to admire friction. I have never had to find out whether my love of a difficult proof would survive a difficult decade. People who have actually lived inside real poverty, real illness without treatment, real captivity, real war, do not typically report that it built their character. They report, when they are able to speak about it at all, exhaustion, and the specific, corrosive fear of a person who does not know whether tomorrow will be survivable. The comfortable have a long, ignoble history of calling other people's suffering formative. This book would like to avoid joining that history, and it is not yet clear, at this early point, that it will manage to.

There is also a smaller, more personal version of the same objection, and it deserves to be named rather than hidden. A philosophy built around the value of resistance is a flattering philosophy for its author to hold, because it makes difficulty sound less like bad luck and more like distinction. I notice, if I am honest, a small pull toward preferring the harder story about myself, the version where struggle explains something, over the plainer truth that some of what I have gone through was simply unfair and taught me nothing worth keeping. I do not think that pull disqualifies the argument. But it needs to be named early, and returned to often, because a writer who will not admit his own incentive to believe a thing is a writer whose belief cannot be fully trusted, including by himself.

None of this can be answered by a better metaphor. The wheel on the ice cannot settle a question about whether hunger builds discipline, because a wheel does not suffer and a hungry child does. What the objection actually demands is a working distinction between the kind of resistance that develops a capacity to respond and the kind that is built, or simply functions, to make responding impossible. Until that distinction can bear real weight in real cases, and not only in comfortable ones, everything written above stays provisional: a set of observations waiting to be tested against exactly the

kind of resistance it would be easiest, and most dishonest, to leave out of the argument.

I think often, now, about the difference between the two kinds of stillness a wheel can suffer. There is the stillness of the wheel on ice, spinning uselessly because there is nothing beneath it to hold onto, all its motion converted into noise and heat and no distance travelled. And there is a different stillness, the one a wheel would suffer if it were wedged instead into a groove too deep to climb out of, gripped so completely by the ground that no turning, however forceful, could move it forward. Both wheels fail to travel. Both look, from a distance, like the same picture: a vehicle going nowhere. But one has failed from an absence of resistance, and the other from a resistance that has stopped being a surface and become a trap.

Somewhere between the ice and the groove there is a kind of ground a wheel can actually use: resistant enough to be pushed against, loose enough to let the pushing turn into movement. I do not yet know how to describe that ground in words sturdy enough to hold a whole philosophy, and I do not think the description can be finished in a single opening. But I know now that freedom was never simply the ice. It has to be somewhere closer to the ground I have not named yet, the ground that pushes back just enough to be pushed against, and I do not expect to find it by wanting, any harder than I already do, for the road to finally stop resisting me.

5. Skill, formation and agency

A foot, before it can carry a body forward, has to find something to push against. This is so basic that it disappears from notice almost immediately after childhood, but it is worth stating anyway, because it is the human version of what the wheel could not do on the ice. Standing still, the sole of the foot rests on the ground and nothing happens. The moment a person means to walk, the foot presses down and slightly back, and the ground, if it is the kind of ground that can be pressed, pushes back in the opposite direction, and that returning push is what actually moves the body forward. The muscles do their part, but the muscles alone would only tense and release in the air. Something outside the body has to answer the pressure for the pressure to become motion.

This is worth pausing on, not because the mechanics of walking are complicated, but because they quietly undo an assumption that survived the whole of the previous discussion mostly unexamined: that force, on its own, is what produces movement. Force is necessary. It is not sufficient. A force that meets nothing capable of resisting it does not become movement. It becomes waste, the specific waste of a wheel spinning on ice, an oar pulled through air instead of water, a hand swung at a bag that has been taken away mid swing. Movement requires a second party. It requires something that will not simply move out of the way.

None of this is a moral argument yet. The ground does not improve the foot by resisting it, any more than a string improves a bow by refusing to vibrate on its own. A person is not made virtuous by having something to push against, and I want to say

this early, because it would be easy, from here, to slide into the sentimental claim that obstacles build character, which is precisely the claim already ruled out. What the foot and the ground show is a structural fact, not a moral one. The simplest movement a body makes already contradicts the idea that freedom is the absence of anything to press against.

Between a single movement and a formed skill lies a long history of exactly this kind of correction, repeated so many times that it stops feeling like correction and starts feeling like knowledge. Someone learning to cook without a written recipe, watching a parent's hands rather than reading measurements, discovers this the hard way. The first attempts follow instruction, more or less, and the result is edible but somehow not right: too much salt in one place, not enough patience in another, the onions taken off the heat a minute before they had anything to teach. The failure is not dramatic, only a small gap between what was intended and what appeared on the plate. But that gap is where the learning happens. The next attempt changes, not because a rule has been added, but because the hand now expects the difference it is about to meet.

The same history shapes anyone learning an instrument. A beginner's hand presses a string with the amount of force intention alone supplies, which is nearly always the wrong amount. The instrument does not care what was intended. It returns a sound that is thin, or sharp, or dead, and that returned sound is information the player did not have a moment earlier. Practise long enough and the hand stops applying a fixed idea of pressure and starts listening, adjusting before the note even sounds, because it has learned what the string is likely to do. The philosopher Michael Polanyi made a version of this point central to his account of skilled knowledge: a great deal of what a skilled person knows cannot be fully stated in words, and a person can know how to do something, and even recognise when it has been done well, without being able to say exactly what the doing consisted of. A skilled hand does not conquer its material. It becomes able to feel, in advance, what the material is about to do.

Mastery, looked at this way, is not the power to make a material do whatever is wanted. In most practices worth taking seriously, mastery is closer to the opposite: an increasing sensitivity to differences a beginner cannot yet perceive. The better musician hears more in the same note. The better cook notices the narrow moment an onion changes from raw to sweet. What looks, from outside, like control over the material is really a finer conversation with it, and the conversation only becomes possible because the material never simply agreed in the first place.

Attention seems to follow a similar pattern, though it leaves less of a visible mark than a badly salted dish. A poem that gives up its meaning on the first reading has, in a sense, not asked anything of the reader. A poem that resists, that holds a phrase back from full sense until the third or fourth pass, forces the reader's attention to become more exact than it would otherwise have needed to be, the way a proof that will not resolve forces a mathematician to look again at an assumption that had seemed too obvious to question. Something similar happens in research, when a result contradicts what the experiment was meant to confirm. The contradiction is often the first real

information the inquiry has produced, not merely an inconvenience to be explained away, because it is the first moment the world declined to simply agree.

But this cannot become an excuse for admiring every difficult thing. Some texts are obscure because their authors never did the work of becoming clear. Some problems are confusing because they were badly designed, not because they are deep. Certain teachers, faced with a question they cannot answer well, will call their own failure to explain it rigour, and a student taught to associate confusion with profundity has no defence against this. Difficulty is not automatically depth. Opacity is not automatically intelligence. What actually matters is whether the resistance answers sustained attention with further structure, the way a difficult proof rewards a second look with relations that were not visible at first, or whether it simply continues to resist without ever offering anything back, the way a badly written paragraph stays exactly as confusing on the tenth reading as it was on the first.

None of this should be mistaken for a claim that difficulty produces growth in proportion to how much of it a person absorbs. A student can solve four hundred nearly identical equations and become faster at that one operation without becoming any more capable of recognising an unfamiliar problem when it appears. A person can spend a decade in a job that exhausts them every day without gaining a single new capacity from the exhaustion. Effort is not the same measurement as formation, and pain is not evidence of seriousness. A locked door and a locked bureaucratic process can both consume a person's whole afternoon, but the door, once opened, has taught the hand something about locks, while the bureaucratic maze, once escaped, has usually taught nothing except how to survive the next maze.

There is a related distinction worth making exactly here, between what forms a person and what only conditions them. Formation leaves someone more able to perceive, judge, and respond to something new. Conditioning leaves someone predictable, shaped by enough repetition, reward, or fear that the person now reliably behaves a certain way without the judgement that would let them behave differently if the situation changed. A student drilled only to reproduce the answer a teacher wants can look, from the outside, exactly like a student who has learned to think, right up until an unfamiliar problem exposes the difference.

So the question worth asking about any given resistance is not how much of it a person endured. Did the encounter create a new perception, or only repeat an old one. Did it enlarge the range of things a person could do next, or only their tolerance for doing the same thing again. Did it produce judgement, or only obedience. Could the person, at any point, revise the terms of what was happening, or refuse it, or leave. A resistance that answers these questions well is doing the kind of work this book cares about. One that fails all of them is not friction in that sense. It is only an obstruction that happened to take up a great deal of time.

6. Writing, evidence and responsibility

The same structure appears, more intimately, in the making of anything. A common but mistaken picture of creation treats the work as something that already exists complete inside the person making it, waiting only to be transferred, without loss, onto paper, canvas, or wood. Writing exposes this picture as false faster than almost any other practice. A thought can feel entirely finished before it enters a sentence. It is only in the writing that its gaps become visible: two ideas that felt identical in the mind turn out, once separated onto the page, not to be identical at all; a conviction that felt emotionally certain turns out, once an argument is required to support it, to have no argument beneath it; a metaphor reached for because it seemed to clarify something turns out, on inspection, to have quietly hidden the very distinction it was meant to make clear.

This is close to what I meant earlier by a language that will not hand private experience across without losing something on the way. The loss is not only a failure. It is also, strangely, a kind of correction. It is exactly in that resistance, in the sentence's refusal to simply obey the thought, that a writer sometimes discovers what he had actually been trying to say, as opposed to what he had merely intended to say before the resistance made the difference visible. A weak writer forces the sentence to obey the first version of the thought regardless of what the sentence is revealing. A stronger one notices when the resistance of the language has exposed a flaw in the plan, and lets the plan change.

A different, though related, kind of resistance operates in inquiry itself. Evidence matters, in science or in ordinary reasoning, specifically because it is capable of refusing a hypothesis. Karl Popper made a version of this central to his account of scientific reasoning: a theory built so that no possible observation could ever count against it is not, for that reason, especially strong. It has simply been protected from the one kind of encounter that would let anyone find out whether it was true. An argument that treats every objection as further proof of itself, that reads all criticism as evidence the critic is trapped inside the very illusion being criticised, has not achieved invulnerability. It has stopped listening.

This should worry a philosophy built around the value of resistance more than it worries most philosophies, because the temptation is obvious and close at hand. It would be easy for Frictionalism to declare every objection raised against it another instance of valuable friction, to absorb each criticism as proof of its own thesis, and to continue unchanged no matter what anyone said. That would not be intellectual courage so much as the sealed argument, dressed in the language of welcoming difficulty. A resistance genuinely allowed to correct a position is different, in kind, from a resistance a position has learned to metabolise without changing. The first is correction. The second, whatever it calls itself, is closer to submission dressed in the language of welcome, a position that has found a way to survive contact with anything by refusing, underneath that welcome, to be moved by it at all.

Gathered together, these are not separate phenomena. A material answers through its properties. A body answers through fatigue, illness, hunger, and the specific limits it makes known usually at the worst possible time. A language answers through ambiguity and its refusal to carry feeling intact. Evidence answers through confirmation or contradiction. Another person answers through interpretation, refusal, consent, disagreement, and the plain fact that they can walk away. None of this means the world literally speaks. It means that action produces consequences no single actor fully authored, and that those consequences can become information if the actor is willing to receive them as such.

This has a direct bearing on responsibility, and it is worth stating plainly before moving on. A person who acts inside a world that answers cannot treat intention as the full measure of what they have done. Meaning well does not erase what occurred. An argument can have consequences its author never intended. Protection, sustained past its purpose, can become control. Teaching, delivered without patience, can become humiliation. Love, held too tightly, can become possession. A reform can end up reproducing the very structure it was built to remove. The answering world takes an action and returns it to the person who performed it, often in a shape they did not expect, and responsibility begins, at least in part, in the willingness to actually receive what comes back rather than insisting on the shape it was meant to have.

It would be dishonest to end this section without asking whether it has been selecting its examples too conveniently. Every case offered so far shows resistance sharpening a capacity: the cook's hand, the musician's ear, the writer's sentence, the scientist's revised hypothesis. But for every musician refined by years of practice, there is another who left the instrument behind because a teacher's contempt made the practice room feel like a courtroom. For every student sharpened by a difficult problem, there is another who learned, from the same kind of difficulty delivered without patience, to associate thinking itself with shame. For every artist whose materials revealed something the plan had missed, there is a worker whose material conditions, the actual conditions of the labour, damaged the body and taught nothing worth keeping. For every disagreement that deepened a friendship, there is one that only exposed how much power one person had always held over the other.

The same outward difficulty can form one person and injure another, and the philosophy cannot pretend this is a minor detail to be handled later. What decides the outcome is not the resistance alone. It is power, resources, how long the difficulty lasts, whether it was in any sense consented to, whether the person had enough security beforehand to absorb a setback, whether rest and guidance were available, and whether the person retained any real possibility of stopping, refusing, or leaving. I do not have a complete account of these thresholds yet, and I do not think one can be produced by argument alone. What can be said now, honestly, is only this: resistance can participate in the formation of a person's agency, but it does not guarantee that formation, and nothing written in this section should be read as though it does.

I go back, at the end of this, to the writing itself, because it is the practice I know

from the inside better than any other. When a sentence first resists, the resistance feels like an obstacle between an intention and its expression, something to be pushed past as quickly as possible so the real thought can finally arrive on the page. It takes longer than it should to notice that the resistance is not standing between the thought and its expression. It is where the thought is actually being found. A sentence that gave way immediately would only have recorded what was already fully known, and a great deal of what actually needs saying is not fully known until the page has refused the first attempt at saying it.

Something in this exceeds the writer's own intention, and that excess is not a flaw in the process. It may be the first real evidence, small and local as it is, that the page is not simply an extension of the hand holding the pen. It behaves like a thing with its own structure, its own resistance, its own refusal to become identical to what was wanted from it before the writing began. Whatever a world is, it may start there, at the point where something stops merely receiving what we intend and begins, instead, to answer it back.

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